

The Minutes of a 1986 reunion of the Subcommittee on Human Rights record an exchange with Lorenzo Natali, Commission Vice-President, who stressed that the Commission differed in its means of action compared to the Parliament. The exchange suggests some tensions in the Parliament getting its voluminous work on human rights to the attention of the Commission.<sup>30</sup> In this case, the Vice-President, however, committed to act as an intermediary between the Subcommittee and Jacques Delors, Commission President, to enable more collaboration.

In an interview, Jean-Pierre Cot, Chair of the Committee on Budgets from 1984 to 1989 and President of the Socialist Group from 1989 to 1994, stated that he experienced the European Parliament's gradual rise in power during that period. He explained that it was not yet a time of co-legislation or co-decision, but the Parliament still held, if not legal power, at least significant influence. He clarified that Parliament was already exerting influence on the Delors Commission. Cot also noted that active MEPs had this influence, and that over time, this growing impact was translated into the co-decision powers recognised by the Treaties.<sup>31</sup>

Apart from seeking to benefit from the change to a collaborative culture brought by the Delors Commission, the European Parliament also used the institutional context created outside the EC to influence political and social outcomes in CEE. The members of the Subcommittee on Human Rights pursued direct contact with eastern European countries through the early mechanisms that the European Political Co-operation (EPC) and the Conference for Security and Cooperation in Europe (CSCE) offered. The CSCE conferences continued the Helsinki process between 1977 and 1989, and the MEPs strived to have their human rights agenda represented in the meetings that the EPC would hold with national delegations from eastern Europe.

However, not all groups saw the urgency in confronting the Soviet Union with the fact that there can be no cooperation and security in Europe without the protection of human rights in the east. In one 1980 debate, the difference between parliamentarians' views on how to approach the upcoming CSCE Madrid Conference are notable. Gérard Israël, speaking on behalf of the Group of European Progressive Democrats, expressed concern over the potential failure of the Madrid Conference, warning that such an outcome could lead to serious repercussions, particularly in eastern Europe, where countries might resort to familiar repressive measures, especially regarding the situation in Poland. In contrast, Jacques Denis, representing the Communist and Allies Group, spoke against urgency in dealing with this matter and was optimistic about the conference's progress, highlighting the strength of détente and cooperation despite initial challenges. He rejected the idea of a return to Cold War attitudes and criticised any confrontational approach coming from what he saw as 'NATO hawks', emphasising a cooperative rather than confrontational path.<sup>32</sup> In this period, the Group of the European Right focused on the rights and freedoms of nations and individuals and pressed for the exposure of Gorbachev to demands for free elections in the countries of the east.<sup>33</sup>

It is not until 1987 that the EPC presidency agrees to receive a delegation of the European Parliament under its umbrella and support MEPs' contacts with delegates from eastern Europe, yet without being allowed to attend plenary sessions or participate in negotiations. For the 1987 CSCE Conference to be held in Vienna, the Subcommittee on Human Rights prepared a dossier of

<sup>30</sup> [Minutes of the Meeting of the Subcommittee on Human Rights](#) (28 February 1986), Historical Archives of the European Union (HAEU), PE2-1579//PE2 AP PV/POLI.1984 SCDH-19860228.

<sup>31</sup> Interview with Jean-Pierre Cot, 28.05.2018 (Gerard Laprat), EUI Oral History Collections, Historical Archives of the European Union (HAEU), INT817-A.1

<sup>32</sup> [Conference on Security and Cooperation in Europe](#) (19 November 1980), Debates of the European Parliament, Historical Archives of the European Union (HAEU), PE1.AP.DE.1980//DE19801119-05/0010.

<sup>33</sup> [Motion for a resolution on a Statement by the European Community to mark the visit to France by Mr. Gorbachev](#) (9 September 1985), Historical Archives of the European Union (HAEU), PE2.AP.PR.1985//B2-0839/85/0010.